



Surprise package: Players like Brian Bennett and Blessing Muzarabani played pivotal roles in Zimbabwe's shock upset of Australia. AP

At the 2022 World Cup in Australia, Zimbabwe had reached the Super 12 stage, where it beat Pakistan. But the significance of that run diminished after the slip-up to Uganda, forcing it to start from scratch and chart a comeback.

"I remember when we were told that we had to play the Sub-Regional Qualifier B in Kenya — sitting down with the squad and saying that either we feel sorry for ourselves and be ashamed or actually understand the reality," captain Sikandar Raza says. "It's because of us that we are in this mess, and it's only we who can get us out of it."

From there, the Chevrons went on to go 11 games unbeaten, winning the Regional Final in the process to get to the World Cup. But the harder part was still ahead — facing the big guns. Through this qualification cycle, Zimbabwe was mindful of not losing ground to higher-ranked Full

Member teams. It invited India, even if a depleted side, to Harare for a five-match series and won the first match, before going down 4-1. South Africa and New Zealand also played a tri-series at the same venue in 2025.

It also registered victories over Sri Lanka, Pakistan and Afghanistan during this World Cup cycle.

The rigorous schedule helped broaden its talent pool. With Blessing Muzarabani and Richard Ngarava having already earned their reputations, the side settled in on other talents like Brian Bennett, Tadiwanashe Marumani and Tashinga Musekiwa through this period. The rewards for backing these players emerged at this World Cup. Bennett's half century (64 off 56) was what tilted the game against Australia in its favour, along with Muzarabani's four for 17. The opening batter starred in the 177-run chase against Sri Lanka too, scoring 63 off 48.

"Over the last 12 to 18 months, while the results in terms of wins haven't quite been there, anyone who's been around has seen consistent improvement in small

Zimbabwe's group stage results



Beat Oman by 8 wickets
Beat Australia by 23 runs
Beat Sri Lanka by 6 wickets
No result vs Ireland

areas. What we see now is a culmination of those key areas," assistant coach Dion Ebrahim says.

The infusion of young blood created a blend of experience and youth. But the team remained centred around the charismatic figure of its leader, Raza.

"I genuinely think we are in the presence of brilliance, and I don't say that lightly. Sikandar has been performing at this level for a while now and perhaps hasn't quite got the accolades others have. He is a global superstar, up there with the greats, and will go down as one of them.

"What does he bring to the dressing room? All those superlatives